

Properties of the thin radiating surface layer of a white dwarf

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(Dated: August 16, 2026)

Keywords: White dwarf;Jellium;Path Integral;Monte Carlo;General Relativity;Thin surface layer

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I. INTRODUCTION

White dwarfs [1] are the dense remnants of stars, composed mainly of carbon and oxygen nuclei, which contain electrons, protons and neutrons and are supported against collapse induced by gravity by the electron degeneracy pressure due to Pauli exclusion principle. They remain white dwarfs till gravity overcomes electron degeneracy pressure, crushing electrons into protons to form neutrons through β^+ decay.

Therefore the simplest model for the interior of a white dwarf is that of *Jellium*. This is a system of pointwise electrons immersed in a uniform neutralizing background. The density of the electron gas is so high that the Fermi temperature is much higher than the temperature of the star and the electron gas can be considered degenerate. Chandrasekar [2–5] model of a white dwarf equilibrium structure didn't take into account the effects of general relativity. First Tolman [6], and later Oppenheimer and Volkoff [7] proposed a way to treat the hydrodynamic equations for the equilibrium and stability of a star within the framework of general relativity.

The luminosity of a white dwarf is due to a thin radiating layer on the star surface (see chapter 4 of the book [1]). The mechanism of a white dwarf cooling is the primary bridge between our theoretical description of the star and observational data which rely on essentially two aspects: luminosity observations and time scale of the observed cooling.

Purpose of this work is to determine the properties of the electron plasma in this thin surface layer using the path integral Monte Carlo (PIMC) method [8] at low non zero temperature. In order to take into account the effects of general relativity we will use the $3 + 1$ foliation of Arnowitt, Deser, and Misner (ADM) [9] to build a density matrix from the stress-energy tensor through a path integral where on each imaginary timeslice one selects a constant time foil [10]. This amounts to treat the quantum Coulomb plasma in the classical Schwarzschild spatial metric outside a spherical shell containing a mass $\mathcal{M}$ as confined in a thin spherical layer of width $\delta \ll \mathcal{R}$ at the surface of the star of radius $\mathcal{R}$. We will then approximate $\mathcal{M}$ as the white dwarf mass.

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The problem of the plasma on the surface of the star, neglecting the radial thickness of the thin layer, has already been treated in Refs. [11–13]. Here we will consider the properties of the ‘atmosphere’ of a white dwarf.

We will also assume that the electrons dispersion relation is the one of non relativistic particles $\epsilon(p) = p^2/2m$. This is reasonable since the density of the electron-proton plasma¹ in the thin surface layer is $\rho_l \approx 10^3 \text{g/cm}^3$ (see section 4.1 of the book [1]) much lower than the central densities. Therefore $p_F^2/m^2c^2 \approx 0.01$ where m is the electron mass and $p_F = \hbar(3n/4\pi)^{1/3}$ is the polarized electrons Fermi momentum.

II. ADM FOLIATION AND SCHWARZSCHILD METRIC

By Birkhoff theorem the vacuum solution of Einstein field equations outside a mass $\mathcal{M}$ is the one of Schwarzschild. Within the ADM foliation

$$\|g_{\alpha\beta}\| = \begin{pmatrix} -(N^2 - N^i N_i) & N_i \\ N_i & g_{ij} \end{pmatrix}, \quad (2.1)$$

the *shift* $N_i = 0$, the *lapse* $N^2 = (1 - R_s/r)$, and $g_{rr} = (1 - R_s/r)^{-1}$, $g_{\theta\theta} = r^2$, $g_{\varphi\varphi} = r^2 \sin^2 \theta$ with $R_s = 2\mathcal{M}$ the Schwarzschild radius. We will generally use a Greek index to denote one of the 4 spacetime components and a Roman index to denote one of the 3 spatial components. We will also introduce ${}^3g = \det\{g_{ij}\} > 0$.

Contracting Einstein field equations in vacuum implies a vanishing scalar curvature, the trace of Ricci tensor. Then Einstein field equations in vacuum reduce to the vanishing of the Ricci tensor. Therefore also the scalar curvature of a spatial foil, at constant time, of Schwarzschild metric must vanish. This will be used later on.

III. PIMC IN A FOIL OF SCHWARZSCHILD METRIC

A many body system composed of N *distinguishable* particles of mass m with positions in $R = (\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2, \dots, \mathbf{r}_N) = (\{\mathbf{r}_l\})$ where each position vector $\mathbf{r}_i = (r_i^1, r_i^2, r_i^3) = (\{r_l^j\})$ in 3 dimensions. On a foil of Schwarzschild solution (2.1) with spatial metric tensor $g_{ij}(\mathbf{r})$, the geodesic distance between two infinitesimally close points R and R' is $ds^2(R, R') = \sum_{l=1}^N ds^2(\mathbf{r}_l, \mathbf{r}'_l)$ where $ds^2(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}') = g_{ij}(\mathbf{r})(\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}')^i(\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}')^j$. Moreover,

$$\tilde{g}_{ij}(R) = g_{i_1 j_1}(\mathbf{r}_1) \otimes \dots \otimes g_{i_N j_N}(\mathbf{r}_N), \quad (3.1)$$

$$\tilde{g}(R) = \prod_{l=1}^N {}^3g(\mathbf{r}_l), \quad (3.2)$$

where $\|\tilde{g}_{ij}\|$ is a matrix made of N diagonal blocks $\|g_{i_l j_l}\|$ with $l = 1, 2, \dots, N$. The Laplace-Beltrami operator on the manifold of dimension $3N$ is

$$\Delta_R = \tilde{g}^{-1/2} \nabla_i (\tilde{g}^{1/2} \tilde{g}^{ij} \nabla_j), \quad (3.3)$$

where $\nabla = \nabla_R$, $\tilde{g}^{ij}$ is the inverse of $\tilde{g}_{ij}$, i.e. $\tilde{g}_{ij} \tilde{g}^{jk} = \delta_i^k$ the Kronecker delta.

The Hamiltonian $\mathcal{H}$ of the N bodies will be

$$\mathcal{H} = -\lambda \Delta_R + V(R), \quad (3.4)$$

where $\lambda = \hbar^2/2m$ and $V(R)$ is the *physical potential* energy of the system, that we here assume only a function of the particles positions and bounded from below.

The density matrix ρ of the system obeys to Bloch equation

$$\frac{\partial \rho(t)}{\partial t} = -\mathcal{H} \rho(t), \quad (3.5)$$

$$\rho(0) = \mathbb{1}, \quad (3.6)$$

where t is the imaginary time with dimension of the reciprocal of energy and $\mathbb{1}$ the identity matrix. The position representation of the density matrix is then obtained from $\rho(R, R'; t) = \langle R | \rho(t) | R' \rangle$ with $\langle R | R' \rangle = \delta(R - R')/\sqrt{\tilde{g}(R)}$

¹ Assuming that the white dwarf is made up of a completely ionized plasma then we may write $\rho = \mu_e m_u n$ with n the electrons number density, m_u the atomic mass unit, and $\mu_e = A/Z$ with Z the atomic number and A the mass number, so that for example for a ${}^4\text{He}$ or a ${}^{12}\text{C}$ white dwarf $\mu_e = 2$ and for a ${}^{56}\text{Fe}$ white dwarf $\mu_e = 56/26 \approx 2.134$.

where δ is a $3N$ dimensional Dirac delta function. In the small imaginary time τ limit the position representation of the density matrix is [13]

$$\rho(R, R'; \tau) \propto \tilde{g}(R)^{-1/4} \sqrt{\mathcal{D}(R, R'; \tau)} \tilde{g}(R')^{-1/4} e^{\lambda \tau \mathcal{R}(R)/6} e^{-\mathcal{S}(R, R'; \tau)}, \quad (3.7)$$

where $\mathcal{R} = 0$ is the scalar curvature of the foil ², $\mathcal{S}$ the action, and $\mathcal{D}$ the van Vleck's determinant [15, 16]

$$\mathcal{D}_{\mu\nu} = -\nabla_\mu \nabla'_\nu \mathcal{S}(R, R'; \tau), \quad (3.8)$$

$$\det ||\mathcal{D}_{\mu\nu}|| = \mathcal{D}(R, R'; \tau), \quad (3.9)$$

where $\nabla = \nabla_R$ and $\nabla' = \nabla_{R'}$. This determinant is the Jacobian of the transformation from the initial conditions given by fixing the pair of momentum and coordinate of each particle to the boundary conditions given by specifying the pair of initial and final coordinates needed in the coordinate representation. The square root of the van Vleck determinant factor takes into account the density of paths among the minimum extremal region for the action (see Chapter 12 of Ref. [16]). The two factors $\tilde{g}^{-1/4}$ are needed in order to have for the density matrix a bidensity for which the boundary condition to Bloch equation is simply a Dirac delta function. In the small $\tau \rightarrow 0$ limit ³ $\tilde{g}(R)^{-1/4} \sqrt{D(R, R'; \tau)} \tilde{g}(R')^{-1/4} \rightarrow (1/2\lambda\tau)^N$.

For the action $\mathcal{S}$, the kinetic-action $\mathcal{K}$, and the inter-action $\mathcal{U}$ we have ⁴

$$\mathcal{S}(R, R'; \tau) = \mathcal{K}(R, R'; \tau) + \mathcal{U}(R, R'; \tau), \quad (3.10)$$

$$\mathcal{K}(R, R'; \tau) = \frac{dN}{2} \ln(4\pi\lambda\tau) + \frac{d\tilde{s}^2(R, R')}{4\lambda\tau}. \quad (3.11)$$

In particular the kinetic-action is responsible for a diffusion of the random walk with a single particle variance equal to $\sigma_{ij}^2(\mathbf{r}) = 2\lambda\tau/g_{ij}(\mathbf{r})$. The inter-action is defined as $\mathcal{U} = \mathcal{S} - \mathcal{K}$ and for potential energies bounded from below one can resort to the Trotter formula [17] to reach the *primitive approximation* ⁵

$$\mathcal{U}(R, R'; \tau) = \tau[V(R) + V(R')]/2. \quad (3.12)$$

Given then an observable $\mathcal{O}$ we can determine its thermal average at an absolute temperature T from

$$\langle \mathcal{O} \rangle = g_s \text{tr} \{ \rho(\beta) \mathcal{O} \} / Z_N, \quad (3.13)$$

$$Z_N = g_s \text{tr} \{ \rho(\beta) \}, \quad (3.14)$$

where $\beta = 1/k_B T$ with k_B Boltzmann constant, $\text{tr}\{\dots\}$ is the trace over the spatial variables, Z_N the canonical partition function, $g_s = 2s + 1$ is the spin degeneracy, and we assumed the Hamiltonian independent from spin. For *identical* bodies the spin-statistics theorem of quantum field theory, dictates that in spatial dimension bigger than two, particles with integer spin are bosons (obeying Bose-Einstein statistics, symmetric wavefunctions), while half-integer spin particles are fermions (obeying Fermi-Dirac statistics, antisymmetric wavefunctions). We will only consider polarized electrons that are fermions with $g_s = 1$.

The position representation of the density matrix at an imaginary time $t = \beta$ is obtained through a *path integral*

$$\rho(R, R'; \beta) = \langle R | \rho(\beta) | R' \rangle = \int \prod_{k=1}^{M-1} \left[\rho(R_k, R_{k+1}; \tau) \sqrt{\tilde{g}(R_k)} dR_k \right] \delta(R_0 - R) \delta(R_M - R') dR_0 dR_M, \quad (3.15)$$

where we have discretized the imaginary time β into M *timeslices* with a small *timestep* $\tau = \beta/M$. The volume element of integration, $\sqrt{\tilde{g}(R)} dR$, can be treated by introducing $W(R) = -\ln[\sqrt{\tilde{g}(R)}]/\tau$ as an effective *geometrical potential*. The many body path $R(t)$ is consequently discretized in M *beads* $R_k = (\{\mathbf{r}_{l,k}\}) = (\{r_{l,k}^j\})$ at each timeslice $k = 1, 2, \dots, M$. We will also call *link* a pair of contiguous beads. Note that in order to measure an observable through Eq. (3.13) it is necessary to consider closed paths such that $R(t + \beta) = R(t)$, or rings on the foil.

For identical electrons, that satisfy to the Fermi-Dirac statistics, one needs to antisymmetrize the distinguishable density matrix (3.15) [18]. In these cases we can then write ⁶

$$\rho_\pm(R, R'; \beta) = \frac{1}{N!} \sum_{\mathcal{P}} \text{sgn}(\mathcal{P}) \rho(\mathcal{P}R, R'; \beta), \quad (3.16)$$

$$\text{sgn}(\mathcal{P}) = (-1)^{\sum_{\nu=1}^N (\nu-1)C_\nu}, \quad (3.17)$$

² The factor depending on the curvature of the manifold is due to Bryce DeWitt [14]. For a space of constant curvature there is clearly no effect, as the term due to the curvature just leads to a constant multiplicative factor that has no influence on the measure of the various observables.

³ Remember that the metric tensor is covariantly constant.

⁴ The expression for $\mathcal{K}$ is the one of Eq. (24.16) of Ref. [16] to lowest order in $R - R'$.

⁵ See Ref. [8] for a numerical analysis of the accuracy of this approximation and for its possible refinements.

⁶ One can antisymmetrize respect to the first, the second, or both the arguments of the distinguishable density matrix. We here choose the first case.

where $\mathcal{P}$ is any permutation of the N particles such that $\mathcal{P}R = (\mathbf{r}_{\mathcal{P}1}, \mathbf{r}_{\mathcal{P}2}, \dots, \mathbf{r}_{\mathcal{P}N})$, with sign $\text{sgn}(\mathcal{P})$. Any permutations can be broken into cycles $\mathcal{P} = \{C_\nu\}$ where C_ν is the number of cycles of length ν in $\mathcal{P}$. An even (odd) permutation has $\text{sgn}(\mathcal{P}) = +1(-1)$ and an even (odd) number of exchanges of a pair of particles.

IV. PIMC CONSTRAINED IN A RADIAL THIN SURFACE LAYER

In order to treat the problem of electrons constrained in a thin spherical shell of width δ we imagine an infinite external potential at $r > \mathcal{R}$ and at $r < \mathcal{R} - \delta$. In the Monte Carlo we reject any move that carry an electron in these two regions.

V. NUMERICAL RESULTS

VI. CONCLUSIONS

AUTHOR DECLARATIONS

Conflicts of interest

None declared.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Funding

None declared.

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